

The Needle of SUSPICION

While wealthy nations are giving every citizen a punch in the arm, India's H1N1 vaccine is still subject to shifting deadlines and a raging debate: to jab or not to jab

| By Damayanti Datta |

On the Sarkhej highway on the outskirts of Ahmedabad, Solapur highway in Pune, NH 7 near Whitefield in Bangalore, Ambala-Chandigarh highway at Lalru—steel-and-glass buildings dot the landscape. From the outside they look like archetypal expressions of new-age planning. Inside, a world of biotech is gathering momentum—whirring steel tanks, moving glass vials, humming fermentors and fast-flowing filters. India is developing a modern flu vaccine for the first time in history. Four pharma majors—Zydus Cadila, Serum Institute, Bharat Biotech and Panacea Biotec—have just got the green signal from the Drugs Controller General of India to start clinical trials. They are chasing time to hit the market with a vaccine that would make or break the country's strategy on the H1N1 pandemic.

With 208 countries reporting at least 14,142 deaths, the pandemic virus has spun a complex tale of its own. It has united the world in ties of fear, split it up over the race for a vaccine, tied it up in knotty blame-games

and offered a real-world drill to find gaps in the way nations handle epidemics. If initially all eyes were turned to the infection, now the spotlight is on vaccination. The rich western half of the world, where the flu is believed to be in decline, has launched a vaccine for every citizen. But in the poorer parts of the world where it's still raging—namely North Africa and South Asia—the vaccine remains a mirage. In India, an endless parade of shifting deadlines, changing strategies, vacillation and debates have pushed back its arrival. Meantime, the virus is on the prowl again. How ready are we?

Not much, beyond airport screenings, a few test centres and antivirals. "We will be among the first few countries to come out with an indigenous vaccine by the end of this year," Union Health Minister Ghulam Nabi Azad had declared at the peak of the pandemic panic. But by October, as vaccines appeared in the western world, it became quite clear that India had been pipped to the post in the vaccine race. The titillating possibility of a homespun vaccine does the rounds every month, as deadlines are systematically pushed back—from January, February, March, April to June 2010.



"ALREADY THE VIRUS HAS SPREAD OUT. BY THE TIME ONE YEAR IS THROUGH, MOST PEOPLE WOULD HAVE ANTIBODIES. THEY WON'T NEED THE VACCINE."

Dr V.M. KATOCH, Director General, ICMR